

Extract from The United Kingdom Merchant Shipping (Accident Reporting and Investigation) Regulations 2012 – Regulation 5:

“The sole objective of a safety investigation into an accident under these Regulations shall be the prevention of future accidents through the ascertainment of its causes and circumstances. It shall not be the purpose of such an investigation to determine liability nor, except so far as is necessary to achieve its objective, to apportion blame.”

As the full investigation report will not be published within 12 months of the accident date, this interim report is published, pursuant to Regulation 14(2)(b) of the Merchant Shipping (Accident Reporting and Investigation) Regulations 2012.

NOTE

This report is not written with litigation in mind and, pursuant to Regulation 14(14) of the Merchant Shipping (Accident Reporting and Investigation) Regulations 2012, shall be inadmissible in any judicial proceedings whose purpose, or one of whose purposes is to attribute or apportion liability or blame.

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Interim report on the investigation of the collision between the high speed passenger craft *Seadogz* and a navigation buoy resulting in one fatality in Southampton Water on 22 August 2020

The aim of this interim report is to inform operators of small high speed passenger craft and UK port authorities of the circumstances of the accident and MAIB's initial findings so that appropriate actions can be taken ahead of the boating season. A full report will be published when the investigation is complete.

The information contained in this interim report is based on investigations to date. Readers are cautioned that new evidence may become available that might alter the circumstances as depicted in this report.

Background

Seadogz Rib Charter Ltd owned and commercially operated two rigid inflatable boats (RIB), *Seadogz* and *Jack Black* (**Figure 1**). The company offered a range of excursions using the boats within the Solent area, which included: *Extreme RIB Experiences*, *Treasure Hunts*, *Corporate Team Building Events*, and trips for Stag and Hen parties. *Seadogz* was approved to operate in area Category 4¹, and its compliance with *The Small Commercial Vessel and Pilot Boat Code of Practice* (SCV Code) was verified by the Yacht Designers and Surveyors Association, a Maritime and Coastguard Agency (MCA) approved certifying authority.



Figure 1: *Jack Black* at Ocean Village marina - illustrating a similar seating arrangement to *Seadogz*

¹ Up to 20 miles from a safe haven, in favourable weather and in daylight.

Seadogz was designed and manufactured by Red Bay Ribs Ltd in 2012 with a high sheer bow, deep 'v'-shaped hull, and inflatable tubes with seven buoyancy chambers. *Seadogz* was equipped with twin 300hp Yamaha outboard engines that, when first fitted, could drive the RIB at speeds of up to 55kts. The passenger seating on *Seadogz* comprised of nine cushioned jockey style seats and one cushioned bench seat that could accommodate three passengers. A semi-circular stainless-steel handrail was provided for each passenger at the front of their seat. Except for the front row seats, the passenger handrails were built into the jockey seat back rests. Due to the staggered configuration of the jockey seats, the handrail for the central position on the bench seat was extended and stiffened by a stainless-steel tie rod. There were two further jockey seats behind the helm console for crew. *Seadogz's* skipper was a highly qualified and experienced RIB driver; he had local knowledge of Southampton Water and had worked for *Seadogz Rib Charter Ltd* on an ad-hoc basis for over 8 years. The North-West Netley buoy was painted green. It weighed about 5 tonnes, had a diameter of 3m and when afloat there was about 4.6m visible above the waterline.

Narrative

At 0930 on 22 August 2020, 11 pre-booked passengers gathered at the RIB operator's meeting point at Ocean Village marina, Southampton, for a 60-minute excursion on board *Seadogz*. The group included two families of four, a party of two and one individual passenger.

Seadogz's skipper introduced himself to the group and explained that the ride would be fast with high speed turns, reaching speeds up to 40kts. The skipper continued with a safety brief, which included instruction on the automatic inflation lifejackets issued and Covid-19 protection measures. Finally, he told the passengers that the boat was "very fast" and that if they felt uncomfortable during the excursion, they should raise their hand in the air and he would bring the boat to a stop. After leading the passengers to the boat the skipper allocated seating, keeping the family groups together as much as possible; three female passengers, a mother and her two daughters, were assigned the bench seat.

At 0946, *Seadogz* departed the marina (**Figure 2**) and moved toward Southampton Water. The weather was overcast with bright spells, the winds were 17kts from the west-south-west with gusts of 25kts, and the sea state was slight.

At 0959, *Seadogz* passed the Weston Shelf buoy (**Figure 2**) at a speed of about 33.1kts. Once clear of the buoy, the skipper put on some loud music and increased to speeds between 30kts and 40kts. During the next 12 minutes *Seadogz* carried out high speed manoeuvres up and down Southampton Water, zig-zagging across the main channel, passing close to navigation buoys and conducting figure-of-eight turns in order to cross its own wake (**Figure 3**).

At 1008, *Seadogz* passed the car ferry *Red Falcon*, which was proceeding on a south-east course down Southampton Water. This offered the skipper an opportunity to drive *Seadogz* across, and so to jump over the ferry's wake. As *Seadogz* passed astern of *Red Falcon* for the fifth time the RIB accelerated on a steady easterly heading for 10 seconds until, at 1011:09 and at a speed of 38.4kts (44.2mph), it collided with the North-West Netley starboard hand buoy (**Figure 4**).

The force of *Seadogz's* head-on impact knocked the buoy over to an almost horizontal position and threw the RIB's bow upwards. The impact and abrupt deceleration forces caused all on board to be thrown violently forward from their seats. Two of the passengers seated in the front row of jockey seats were thrown out of the boat and into the water where their lifejackets inflated automatically.

Injuries and damage

Everyone on board *Seadogz*, except for one passenger, sustained injuries during the collision, including; broken limbs, fractured vertebrae, dislocations and a punctured lung. Emily Lewis, a 15-year-old passenger who was sitting on the bench seat in the middle, sustained fatal internal injuries.

The forward three sections of the buoyancy tubes on *Seadogz's* port side were punctured and the bow of the GRP hull was severely damaged. Several of the steel framed jockey seat backs were bent forward by the force of passengers hitting them.